

Need & Needn't

CEFR B2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

'Need' works two ways — as an ordinary verb and as a modal in the negative:

- 1 need to + base verb — necessity (You need to sign here).
- 2 needn't / don't need to — not necessary (You needn't come).
- 3 past: didn't need to = wasn't necessary; needn't have = you did it unnecessarily.

'Needn't have + participle' means you actually did it and it was a waste. 'Didn't need to' just means it wasn't necessary.

At a glance

Form	Meaning	Example
need to + base verb	it's necessary	You need to book early.
needn't / don't need to + base verb	it isn't necessary	You needn't book — there's space.
didn't need to + base verb	it wasn't necessary (so maybe not done)	I didn't need to cook.
needn't have + past participle	you did it, but it was unnecessary	I needn't have cooked.

Learning objectives

- Can use 'need to' and 'needn't/don't need to' for (lack of) necessity (CEFR B2).
- Can contrast 'didn't need to' with 'needn't have + participle'.
- Can form the modal 'needn't' without 'to'.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Need & Needn't · CEFR B2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. You ____ book in advance — the restaurant is never full.

- | | |
|---------------|---------------|
| A. needn't | B. need |
| C. needn't to | D. don't need |

2. I ____ renew my passport before the trip.

- | | |
|------------|---------------|
| A. need to | B. needn't |
| C. need | D. needn't to |

3. I ____ cooked — nobody was hungry and it all went to waste.

- | | |
|------------------|-------------------|
| A. needn't have | B. didn't need to |
| C. don't need to | D. needn't |

4. We ____ hurry — the train doesn't leave for an hour.

- | | |
|------------------|-------------------|
| A. don't need to | B. need to |
| C. needn't have | D. didn't need to |

5. In the end I ____ pay, because my friend had already paid.

- | | |
|-------------------|-----------------|
| A. didn't need to | B. needn't have |
| C. don't need to | D. needn't |

6. 'She needn't have brought a gift.' means...

- | | |
|---|-----------------------------|
| A. She brought a gift, but it wasn't necessary. | B. She didn't bring a gift. |
| C. She must bring a gift. | D. She will bring a gift. |

7. Do we ____ bring our own towels?

- | | |
|------------|---------------|
| A. need to | B. needn't |
| C. need | D. needn't to |

8. Correct this: 'You needn't to worry about it.'

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| A. You needn't worry about it. | B. You needn't to worry about it. |
| C. You needn't worrying about it. | D. You don't needn't worry about it. |

9. 'I didn't need to water the plants' most likely means...

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|
| A. It wasn't necessary, so I probably didn't. | B. I watered them and it was a waste. |
| C. I must water them now. | D. The plants watered themselves. |

10. Which form means 'you did it, but it was unnecessary'?

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| A. needn't have + past participle | B. didn't need to + base verb |
| C. don't need to + base verb | D. need to + base verb |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. needn't** — 'Needn't' + base verb = it isn't necessary.
2. **A. need to** — Necessity: 'need to renew'.
3. **A. needn't have** — You did it unnecessarily: 'needn't have cooked'.
4. **A. don't need to** — Present, not necessary: 'don't need to hurry'.
5. **A. didn't need to** — It wasn't necessary and I didn't: 'didn't need to pay'.
6. **A. She brought a gift, but it wasn't necessary.** — 'Needn't have + participle' = she did it, unnecessarily.
7. **A. need to** — Questions use 'need to' with 'do': 'Do we need to bring...?'
8. **A. You needn't worry about it.** — Modal 'needn't' + base verb: 'needn't worry'.
9. **A. It wasn't necessary, so I probably didn't.** — 'Didn't need to' = it wasn't necessary (often not done).
10. **A. needn't have + past participle** — 'Needn't have + participle' = done unnecessarily.